Jim Rogers
1942–

Jim Rogers made millions as George Soros' first partner and then on his own. He grew up in the small, isolated Alabama town of Demopolis, where at age five he first started making money by picking up bottles after baseball games. While a capitalist at heart, he was unsure of what he wanted to do with his life; so, after graduating from Yale in 1964, he decided to take a summer job with a securities firm and then go to Oxford in the fall to study economics, philosophy, and politics. After Oxford and a stint in the Army he returned to investing. As he once said, "What I liked about it was not so much investing money, because at that time I didn't have any, but that if you were smart, used your wits, and paid attention to the world it was all you had to do."

Rogers, who has made his mark as an international investor, likes to wager not on a few stocks, but on whole countries that he feels are better off than most others realize. For example, he started investing in Portugal in the mid-1980s right after the communist government was overthrown—against the advice of a Portugese investment firm. Rogers bought all 24 stocks on the Lisbon exchange and made a killing. Part of his success is simply finding ways to invest in a country that has few or no financial institutions catering to investors. When Rogers was interested in putting money in Brazil, a stock exchange official there told him the only way for foreigners to do so was through the black market. Rogers asked where the black market was, and the official replied, he was it.

In 1990, Rogers and his girlfriend set out to travel the world by motorcycle. Over the next 22 months, they traveled 65,067 miles, a record. When he arrived back, people asked Rogers how the United States looked to him. His response: "I hate to say it, because this is my home, but I see America as an obvious short." He believes we're still too isolated from the world and are unwilling to address our economic problems. In *Get Smart . . . and Make a Fortune,* Rogers explains why it's important to not turn a blind eye and to listen to what others are saying, especially in the media, when determining the optimal time to buy and sell securities.